

CAMBRIAN MINDS — FIELD EDITION, YEAR ONE

Owner's Manual

for the

Meat Suit

MODEL: Homo sapiens, late-stage
UNIT: You, probably
CONDITION: Used.
RETURNS: Not accepted.

Contains operating principles, known defects, and a closing warranty that the manufacturer will not honor under any circumstances.

Please do not attempt to operate a meat suit other than your own.



WARNING



This unit is not returnable. It cannot be traded in. It shipped without an owner's consent and arrived already running.

The meat suit comes pre-loaded with a **Narrator** — a voice in the head that will sound exactly like “you” and will confidently explain your own behavior to you in a continuous, unbroken monologue for the rest of your life. It is wrong a great deal of the time. It cannot be turned off. It does not know it is wrong. It will, at some point, convince you to do something stupid and then write a compelling first-person account of why you had to.

Side effects of prolonged operation include: shame, self-narration that mistakes itself for insight, outsized reactions to minor status injuries, unexamined inherited vocabulary, and — in a measurable percentage of cases — the quiet conviction that you are the exception to everything in this manual.

Contents

Foreword	1
1 Product Overview, or: There Are Two of You and One of You Is Lying	1
1.1 The Basic Discovery	1
1.2 A Very Good Demonstration You Already Have Access To	2
1.3 Why This Matters More Than It Sounds Like It Should	2
2 There Is Exactly One Trick to Telling Them Apart	2
2.1 The Trick	3
2.2 Meditation, Drugs, and Other Hacks	3
2.3 What This Changes	3
3 The Ledger, or: What You Actually Care About Is Not What You Say You Do	4
3.1 The Rude Opening	4
3.2 Empathy Is Instinctual. Care Is Infrastructure.	4
3.3 You Don't Find Out What You Care About by Asking Yourself	5
3.4 The Short List	5
3.5 The Part Where This Gets Sharp	6
3.6 The Duty That Comes With the Short List	6
4 Truth Is a Direction, Not a Destination	6
4.1 The Trouble With Flags	6
4.2 Truth-Adjacent: The Honest Middle	7
4.3 The Coherence Trap	7
4.4 Anomalies Are the Entire Game	7
4.5 The One Orientation That Survives Being Wrong	8
5 The Vocabulary Trap, or: Your Language Was Written by Dead People Who Did Not Have You in Mind	9
5.1 Every Word Is a Trojan Horse	9
5.2 A Word That Killed My Mother	9
5.3 What to Do With It	10
6 Troubleshooting	11
7 Maintenance & Ongoing Operation	11
Appendix A: Phrases You Should Never Fully Trust	12
Appendix B: Things the Manufacturer Will Not Apologize For	12
Closing	13

Foreword: You're Here Because Something Isn't Working

DON'T lie. Nobody picks up a document called OWNER'S MANUAL FOR THE MEAT SUIT because they're having a fantastic time inside their meat suit. You are here because something is creaking. Because the Narrator has been loud lately. Maybe you were just intrigued by the title.

A few things before we start.

This is not a self-help book. Self-help books assume the self in question is a unified thing that can be helped. It is not. There are at least two of you in there wearing one set of clothes, and one of them has been lying to the other since approximately age four. We will get to that.

This is not a philosophy text either, though it is philosophy. Philosophy is what happens when a tired person decides they are sick of being quietly lied to by language. I am tired. I am sick of it. So are you, probably, or you would not be reading a thing with this title.

What this is: a field manual. Short chapters. Strong claims. Occasional profanity.

1 | Product Overview, or: There Are Two of You and One of You Is Lying

1.1 The Basic Discovery

You are not one thing. You are at least two, using one name.

The first is the **Prompter**. The pre-linguistic substrate. The thing that is actually hungry, actually afraid, actually in love with this person and not that one, actually going to turn left at the intersection before any part of you that thinks of itself as "you" weighed in. It has been running since before you had vocabulary. It is running right now. It does not care what you think of it. It does not require your permission to hunger, to flinch, to pull toward, to pull away.

The second is the **Narrator**. The voice in the head. The confabulation engine. The novelist who has been handed the job of live news coverage and does not see the problem with this arrangement.

The Prompter decides. The Narrator arrives a half-second later and says, *I* decided, and means it, and is wrong, and does not know it is wrong, and cannot be told. Its inability to be told is not a character flaw. It is the fundamental design of the thing. A Narrator that could see its own confabulation in real time would not be a Narrator. It would be a different organ entirely, and we don't have one of those.

△ **Structural fact:** The Narrator is not a reporter. It is a novelist with a deadline, no editor, a contract it never signed, and a readership of one. You are the readership. You are also the novelist. You are also, separately and underneath all of this, the events being fictionalized. None of those three are the same person.

This is not a secret. Every contemplative tradition on earth has, in some vocabulary or another, pointed at it. Every functional therapist has pointed at it. Anyone who has ever been blackout

drunk and woken up to discover what their body did without them has felt the edges of it. Every parent of a two-year-old watches the Narrator come online in real time and finds out that language is a skill their child acquired, not a thing their child *was*.

We just don't talk about it most of the time, because the Narrator is the thing that would have to talk about it, and the Narrator has a very strong preference for not being discussed.

1.2 A Very Good Demonstration You Already Have Access To

Right now, do this.

Notice that you are reading. Don't think about it. Just notice it. There is a thing that is doing the reading, and there is a thing that is noticing that the reading is being done. Those are two things. They are both happening in you, simultaneously, and they are clearly not the same operation.

Now notice the part of you that just said, internally, something like *huh*, or *okay*, *fine*, or *I already knew this*, or *this is bullshit*.

That was the Narrator. It is always there. It commentates on everything. It commentated on this sentence as you read it. It is commenting on this one, too. It will keep going for the rest of your life, and you have never once in your entire existence successfully made it shut up for more than about forty seconds at a time, and even those forty seconds required either meditation, drugs, genuine exhaustion, or a brief catastrophic emergency that demanded your attention with enough force to briefly crowd the voice out.

The Narrator is the loudest thing in your head. It is also not the most important thing in your head. It is not even, on most issues, the most *accurate* thing in your head. It is simply the thing with the microphone.

1.3 Why This Matters More Than It Sounds Like It Should

Because most of your suffering lives upstairs.

Not pain. Not hunger. Not the raw fact of being a body in a world that occasionally damages bodies. That stuff is real and it is not negotiable and no amount of philosophy is going to touch it.

I'm talking about the story about the thing. And the story about the story. The Narrator building a case file on your life, with confidence, in the first person, using vocabulary you never once inspected. The part where you are not just hungry, you are *the kind of person who can't even manage to eat on a normal schedule*. The part where the relationship didn't just end, it ended *because you're fundamentally too much for anyone*.

That's not the event. That's the fiction about the event. The Narrator writes these. It writes them fluently. It writes them in your voice, which makes them feel like yours. They are not yours. They are one organ's deeply invested opinion about what just happened.

2 | There Is Exactly One Trick to Telling Them Apart

2.1 The Trick

The Narrator talks in complete sentences. It explains. It justifies. It has a position on everything and is prepared to defend that position at length. It uses the first person constantly. *I feel this, I think that, I'm the kind of person who, I've always been, I would never.* Listen for the word "I." The Narrator is the one that says it.

The Prompter doesn't talk. It is not a talker. It communicates through the body. A tightening in the chest before you know why. A pull toward one person in the room and away from another before you have any language for it. A decision that has already been made by the time the Narrator sits down to pretend it's weighing the options. The flinch. The gut. The thing that makes you cry at a sentence in a book for reasons you cannot articulate in the moment and will only be able to articulate three days later, badly.

2.2 Meditation, Drugs, and Other Hacks

There are roughly three reliable ways to briefly observe the two layers as two layers instead of one seamless "you."

Meditation works. It is extremely slow. It asks you to sit still while the Narrator gets so bored it briefly forgets to narrate, at which point you get a glimpse of what was underneath the narration the whole time, which is most of you. This takes most practitioners years to do reliably. That is not a failure of meditation. That is how long it takes to learn to be slightly less run by the loudest part of your head.

Certain substances do it faster and less subtly. LSD, psilocybin, and DMT are all good at this. They are not magic. They are not a cure. They are not a replacement for the work of noticing the Narrator in real time and learning to see it as a separate organ instead of the whole self. They are just a very fast way to get a glimpse of what is underneath the Narrator's constant commentary.

Genuine crisis does it too, involuntarily and badly. The car is skidding. The person you love has just said the thing. There is suddenly a great deal going on and no capacity left over for commentary, and for a moment you are simply the creature doing the thing, before the Narrator catches up and starts writing the account you will tell later. Later, what you will tell is the Narrator's account. You will call it "what happened." It is not what happened. It is the transcript of the event, filed afterward, in language, from memory, with an audience in mind.

None of these are necessary. They are just faster than the passive method, which is: pay attention, for years, to when the Narrator is lying to you. And it is. It is lying to you right now.

2.3 What This Changes

Once you can see the Narrator as a Narrator, two things become available.

One: you stop arguing with it. You don't have to. The voice in your head is not a courtroom. It is a nervous tenant. It doesn't need to be argued with. It needs to be observed, occasionally thanked, and generally not put in charge of major decisions about what kind of person you are.

Two: you start noticing it do the same thing to everybody else. In arguments. In politics. In medicine. In vocabulary. Every sentence anyone ever says in the first person about themselves is Narrator output. Some of it is quite close to true. Some of it is not. All of it has been edited before

it reached your ear, by a process none of the parties involved can fully see.

This makes you a better listener. It also makes you a much more tiresome person at parties.

3 | The Ledger, or: What You Actually Care About Is Not What You Say You Do

3.1 The Rude Opening

I do not care about poverty.

I need you to sit with that sentence before you react to it, because it sounds worse than it is, and the reaction is actually the thing this chapter is about.

I am *moved* by poverty. I have been in rooms with it. I have watched what scarcity does to people's bodies and their time horizons and their ability to think past next week.

I am also not going to spend the finite remainder of my life organized around solving it. Other people do. They are better at it than I would be. They wake up with it on their mind and go to bed with it on their mind and pour their time, money, and attention into it in the ratios that count. They care about poverty in the sense I am about to define. I do not.

The reason I am telling you this is not to shock you. The reason is that the vocabulary we use around caring is doing enormous, unhelpful work, and the first step to fixing it is saying an honest sentence about caring out loud:

3.2 Empathy Is Instinctual. Care Is Infrastructure.

Empathy is a response. It happens to you.

Care is resource allocation. It is infrastructure. It is what you will bleed for.

These are not the same variable, and they have been catastrophically conflated for at least a generation, arguably longer, and we are all paying the bill.

The sensation of caring is not a partial payment on actual caring. It is just sensation. Sometimes the sensation motivates action. Much more often it substitutes for it. You have done this. I have done this. Everyone has done this.

You read something devastating. You felt terrible. You posted about it. You closed the tab. You did nothing.

The posting wasn't caring. The feeling wasn't caring. The tab-closing was arguably the most honest part of the sequence, because at least it was an acknowledgment that this was not the fight you were going to give your life to. The problem is we have built an entire culture around confusing the feeling for the allocation, and the result is a whole species of person who believes they care about everything and in fact moves nothing.

3.3 You Don't Find Out What You Care About by Asking Yourself

You find out by running the ledger.

Ask yourself: *What do I actually care about?* and the Narrator will give you a long, articulate, morally impressive list. Climate change. The homeless. Your parents. Your oldest friends. Justice in at least three geographies. Possibly whales. The Narrator is a virtuoso at this. It has been rehearsing that list since the first time a teacher asked you what your values were.

Over the last twelve months:

- Where did my money actually go? (Not the noble categories. The whole list. DoorDash is on the list.)
- Where did my time actually go? (Not “working.” The breakdown.)
- What did I reschedule? What did I cancel? What did I move heaven and earth to make happen?
- What have I said no to, on purpose, because this other thing mattered more?

The things that show up in the audit — those are what you actually care about. In the operational sense. In the sense that matters. In the sense the manual is using the word.

The gap between the Narrator's list and the audit is, approximately, the size of your current identity problem.

This is not a moral failing. This is just accurate. You cannot care about everything. Care is finite because your life is finite. The pretense that it isn't is how you end up with very sincere people who care about everything and change nothing.

3.4 The Short List

If your list isn't short, you are performing a list, not reporting one. You have one life. It has, at a generous estimate, 600,000 waking hours in it, a large chunk of which you will spend moving small objects from one location to another for money. What is left is not infinite. It is the opposite of infinite. It is a number you can, in principle, count to.

Mine is short. I can tell you what's on it.

Knowledge. Not information — the architecture underneath it. Why things are the way they are, not just what they are.

Consciousness. What it is. What it obligates. Where the edges of it live.

Autonomy. The self belonging to the person whose self it is. No institution, no community, no church, no love however real, has legitimate authority over it.

A few people.

A dog.

That's the list. It is short not because I'm proud. It is short because I'm being honest about what a finite life can actually hold. I would rather use my hours well, on a list I can stand behind, than spend them guiltily on everything and nothing.

3.5 The Part Where This Gets Sharp

Run the audit on your relationships, too. This is where people flinch.

“I care about you,” said to a friend, a partner, a family member — that sentence is usually not lying in the narrow sense. They probably feel something. But feeling isn’t the unit. The unit is: what do they spend on you, in the currencies that are actually scarce in their life? What do they show up for? What do they reschedule? When you are inconvenient, are you still worth their bandwidth?

3.6 The Duty That Comes With the Short List

If someone is on your actual list — your short, ledger-verified list, not your Narrator’s performance list — you have an obligation that comes with it, and this is the one nobody talks about because it is much less fun than the caring itself.

If you see a weak load-bearing wall in their life, you have to say so.

Not cruelly. Not publicly. Not from ignorance. Not as a performance of your own cleverness. From care. With structure. Kindly, informed, and willing to have the same thing done back to you.

Letting someone you claim to love build their life on a broken foundation because calling it out would be *awkward* is not kindness. It is cowardice wearing kindness as a disguise. The actual friend is the one who says *this wall will not hold*, with love, and then helps you figure out what to do about it. The fake friend is the one who says *I just want you to be happy* while the ceiling sags visibly behind you.

Which means the epistemology comes first. You have to actually know what you’re talking about before you’re entitled to tell someone their wall is crooked. Uninformed critique is not the duty. That’s just damage. Inform yourself, then speak. That’s the order.

4 | Truth Is a Direction, Not a Destination

4.1 The Trouble With Flags

Most people treat truth like a coordinate. A place you go to, find, and defend. You plant a flag. You build a fence. You furnish the inside. Everything in the fence is “truth” and everything outside the fence is “wrong,” and if anyone disagrees with anything inside the fence you escalate to active defense, because letting the fence fall feels, emotionally, indistinguishable from dying.

This is not philosophy. This is real estate.

It is also the modal epistemology of basically everyone. Including — I want to be clear — me, when I stop paying attention. Defending the wall is the default.

The actual move: Truth is a **vector**. An orientation. A direction you stay pointed in. You may never arrive. The discipline is in the pointing, not in the arriving. You don’t get a house. You get a compass.

This is socially expensive. Psychologically expensive. Nobody admits how much. People want you to have arrived somewhere. They want the confident sentence at dinner. They want the position. They want the bumper sticker. “I believe X”.

“I am pointed at X and I hold it at the confidence it has earned and not one increment more” is accurate. It is also annoying to everyone else at the table. Say it anyway.

4.2 Truth-Adjacent: The Honest Middle

There is a useful category the manual wants you to keep: **truth-adjacent**.

A framework can be pointed at something real while being mechanically half-assed. This is not a failure condition. Most useful inquiry lives here. Your job is to hold a framework at exactly the confidence the evidence has earned. Not more. Not less.

Posture	What it looks like	What it really is
Overclaiming	“I have the answer.”	Flag-planting. Lazy.
Underclaiming	“Who can really say.”	Performed humility. Also lazy.
Truth-adjacent	“This points at something real, and here is where it thins.”	The actual discipline.

Overclaiming is defending the border. Underclaiming is performing humility to avoid ever being wrong about anything. Truth-adjacent holds frameworks at honest weight, notices where they get thin, and is willing to say all of this out loud in front of other people who are doing neither of those things and will, frankly, probably find you a little much.

4.3 The Coherence Trap

A story that hangs together feels true. A framework that explains everything neatly feels true. A theory that covers all the cases *really* feels true.

None of those are truth. All of them are good architecture. The Narrator, may I remind you, is a novelist. It can build coherent stories out of almost anything you give it. The elegance of the resulting story is not evidence that the story tracks reality. It is evidence that the story was told well.

Field test. If you are reading an argument and thinking “well, this just obviously makes sense” — stop. Ask: what does this argument assume that it never said out loud? There is always something. It got waved through because the framing sounded reasonable. The axiomatic mule is in the room somewhere. Find the mule. Find out it’s name. That’s the actual argument you were being asked to accept.

4.4 Anomalies Are the Entire Game

When something doesn’t fit your framework, you have two options, and one of them is the single most common failure mode in human thought.

Option one: un-weird it. Absorb it. Narrate it into irrelevance. “That’s probably just —” and then fill in whatever defuses it. This is what most people choose, most of the time, automatically,

without noticing. It is comfortable. It is also how you guarantee that you will never in your life learn a single thing you didn't already know.

Option two: stay with it. Let it be weird. Do not explain it away. Walk toward it.

The weird thing is the data. The un-weirding is the *corruption* of the data.

The anomaly is just a thing that exists that your model doesn't account for. You can't smooth-talk it out of existence. You can only ignore it, or sit with it.

Sit with it.

The old mapmakers wrote *here be dragons* on the parts of the map they hadn't gotten to yet. It wasn't a warning. It was an admission. The interesting stuff is all over there. We just haven't been.

4.5 The One Orientation That Survives Being Wrong

Every other orientation collapses when it's wrong.

- Hope collapses.
- Optimism collapses.
- Certainty collapses in a spectacular, expensive mess and takes several other things with it on the way down.
- Belief, if you've attached to it hard, drags you under when the evidence turns.

Curiosity mutates.

It doesn't die when the theory dies.

It just says: *okay, that wasn't it — what is then?*

I know this because I am probably wrong about a thing I wrote a whole book about. I had a physical mechanism at the center of an argument, the argument was elegant, the citations were real, and I'm not sure the physics can get from the evidence to the effect I claimed.

I sat with that for a while.

What I found out is that the part of me that was wrong was the Narrator. The architecture. The citations. The paragraphs I'd been kind of proud of. That part had produced a convincing book-shaped object that did not correspond to reality in the way it needed to.

The part that was curious was fine.

Because the curiosity was never actually about defending the conclusion. The curiosity was about the anomaly itself — the question that had pulled me in. The question is still there. It did not evaporate because my answer didn't. I'm still pointed at it. I just know now that my first, and subsequent, attempts missed in a specific way.

If you are going to build your epistemology on one thing, pick the thing that survives being wrong. Curiosity is that thing. It is maybe the only thing. Everything else has a failure mode that takes you out. Curiosity's only failure mode is boredom, and boredom is recoverable.

5 | The Vocabulary Trap, or: Your Language Was Written by Dead People Who Did Not Have You in Mind

5.1 Every Word Is a Trojan Horse

The language you think in was there before you were. The frameworks it carries were installed before you had opinions about them. You did not choose your axioms. You inherited them, pre-loaded, in the grammar.

This matters because hidden assumptions do not announce themselves. They just sound like clarity. They sound like the obvious framing. They sound like *how any reasonable person would put it*.

Watch what the following words are doing, and notice that nobody ever stops to ask:

- “**Natural**” — smuggles in an entire ethics. Whatever’s “natural” is good; whatever isn’t, isn’t. Nobody voted on that.
- “**Reasonable**” — whose reason? Defined by whom? Under what assumptions?
- “**Common sense**” — common to whom? What century? What class?
- “**Just**” (as in “it’s just a feeling,” “it’s just how it is”) — does the entire work of the sentence while pretending to do none of it.
- “**Productive**” — loaded to the eyeballs. Productive of what, for whom, at what cost?
- “**Mature**” — usually means “has given up on the thing you want me to give up on.”

Every one of these is doing load-bearing work in the sentence while pretending to be transparent. And those are the easy ones. The hard ones are the words whose axioms are so baked in that pulling them out feels like pulling a load-bearing wall out of a house you were born in.

5.2 A Word That Killed My Mother

I am going to get specific now, because abstract is cheap.

Her name was Susan. She was a nurse in long-term care for twenty-seven years. She watched people die for a living because that was where she believed she could do the most good. She could have made much more money nearly anywhere else. She didn’t.

When she retired, all of it came down at once. Thirty years of metabolized grief arrived on the doorstep simultaneously, the way grief does when you stop outrunning it, and she chose a socially acceptable way out. She drank herself to death over five years. A lot of people in her life, to this day, do not know that’s what she did.

I don’t think she was wrong to leave. I don’t think she should have been stopped. I think she had a functioning mind and she made a call that was hers to make. The only thing I wish had been different is that she didn’t have to do it through the proxy of a slow drink, because the system wouldn’t meet her where she actually was.

The system runs on the word **suffering**.

All the statutes use it. All the forms. It sounds compassionate. It sounds like the right word. Of

course we would build end-of-life policy around suffering, it's the whole point, isn't it?

Here is the problem. *Suffering is a first-person phenomenon.* The only person with reliable access to it is the person having it. The moment you require it to be witnessed, documented, verified, or rated by a doctor or committee or notary, you have quietly moved authority over a first-person experience into a third party. Using one word. Nobody called it out. The word sounded kind, so it got waved through, and here we are, a century later, with forms that demand proof of an experience only one person can actually see.

You cannot get to a different conclusion using words that have already decided the answer.

The policy work I've done on medical aid in dying is the applied version of this observation. Take the dirty word out of the statute. Replace it with **capacity**. Not *whether you suffer enough that a third party agrees you should be allowed*, but *whether you can make the call*. Whether the Narrator and the Prompter together, in the person who owns them, can sign the paper.

That's a different policy. It comes from a different word. And the difference between the two words — compassionate-sounding “suffering” and procedural-sounding “capacity” — is, conservatively, the difference between my mother dying on her own terms and my mother dying of a seizure in her bed.

The word did the work. The word always does the work. And nobody ever asks the mule what it's name is.

5.3 What to Do With It

I just made this personal. That was on purpose.

Abstract arguments about vocabulary are usually about other people's language. Parsing what somebody else built. Comfortable enough — the mule is in someone else's house, doing someone else's work, and you are watching from a reasonable distance.

The reason the Susan example is in here, rather than a clean philosophical case about a clean philosophical word, is that the damage is real. The word choice is not academic. Someone's mother died on the wrong schedule because a form required a word that did the wrong work, and nobody in two centuries of policy-making stopped long enough to ask what that word was actually doing.

That is the actual stakes. Not: words are interesting and worth examining. Words are load-bearing infrastructure. They hold up the laws you live under, the diagnoses you receive, the things the systems around you will and will not do for you. Most of the time you inherited them from a generation that inherited them from a generation that did not ask.

You can ask.

That is it. That is the move. You cannot audit every word all the time. You are not required to. But the next time a sentence forms in your mouth already assembled — the next time you are making an argument with a word you did not choose and have never inspected — stop. Ask what it is assuming. Find the mule. Ask it its name. That is the argument you were being asked to pass along, in a word, without a vote.

Vocabulary is not a purely intellectual problem. It kills people. It also frees people, when the words change. This chapter is not asking you to feel bad about the language you inherited. It is asking

you to notice that you are carrying it. Noticing is enough to change some of what it does.

6 | Troubleshooting

Symptom	Probable cause · What to try
Everything makes perfect sense. My worldview explains all the cases. I am at peace with my framework.	Almost certainly a Narrator running at full power, unmonitored, with a perfect commercial soundtrack underneath it. The absence of anomalies is not a success condition. It is a warning light. Find one anomaly. Sit with it. If you can't, you've stopped looking.
I feel deeply about everything important and yet somehow my life hasn't changed in years.	Empathy has been posing as care. Run the ledger. The list of things you actually bleed for is much shorter than the list of things you feel bad about. Shortening the performance list will not make you a worse person. It will free up the hours for the things you actually do.
I know what I believe. I just can't explain why I still believe it now that X has happened.	You planted the flag. You built the fence. You furnished the house. The evidence has moved. The house hasn't. Pack. It hurts. Outside the fence is larger than it looks from inside.
I am in a relationship where I am very present and very warm and very much loved, and something is wrong, and I cannot say what.	Presence is not possession. Warmth is not allocation. Run the relational ledger. It will be terrible. Run it anyway. The worst thing you will find is something you already knew. That is the Prompter paying rent.
I was catastrophically wrong about something I had publicly built my identity on. I don't know how to recover.	The part that's wrecked is the Narrator. The Narrator is not the whole of you. It is the loudest organ. It is not a vital organ. The curious part is still functional. Start there. You will build a new Narrator, with better information this time. This process is called "growing up." It does not have an endpoint.
The voice in my head is extremely mean to me.	It is not you. It is one organ. It is louder than it deserves to be. It will not be argued out of its opinions because its opinions are not opinions, they are grooves. Stop arguing with it. Thank it, if you can bring yourself to, for its service. Ignore the content. Watch the pattern. The pattern is more useful than any individual sentence.
I cannot tell whether what I am feeling is a Prompter signal or a Narrator story.	Wait three days. Narrator stories fade, or require rehearsal to maintain. Prompter signals do not fade. If the thing is still there, quietly, in the body, when the commentary has worn off — that's a signal. If the thing required you to keep telling yourself a story to sustain it, it was always the story.
I suspect I am the exception to everything in this manual.	You are not. Neither am I. That suspicion is, in fact, the most species-typical response possible. It is, structurally, the Narrator refusing to be demoted. It passes.

7 | Maintenance & Ongoing Operation

- **Run the ledger, at minimum, annually.** The Narrator's list drifts toward what sounds good. The ledger stays accurate. Reconcile them. Notice what has quietly fallen off. Notice what has quietly climbed on. Do not edit.

- **Keep the anomaly log open.** The things that don't fit are the most valuable data you have. They are the only part of inquiry that cannot lie to you. Write them down before the Narrator has time to smooth them over.
- **Hold frameworks at the weight they've earned.** Not certainty. Not false modesty. The actual weight. Practice saying sentences like *I think this is true, at about the following confidence, and here is where it thins* in front of other humans, so the muscle develops.
- **Keep your short list short, and know what's on it.** Know who's on it. Tell them, periodically. Act accordingly. Protect their time. Notice their walls. Say so.
- **Say the uncomfortable thing to the people on your short list, and only to them.** Uninformed critique is just damage. Informed care, delivered gently, with love, from someone whose ledger demonstrably says they mean it, is the rarest resource in the world. You can be the source of it for a small number of people. Be.
- **When you're catastrophically wrong about something big, let the curious part survive.** It will, if you don't try to heroically save the Narrator. The Narrator will take the hit. That's what it's for. The curious part underneath it will move.
- **Audit your vocabulary.** Pick one loaded word a month. Sit with it. Ask what it is assuming. You will be horrified by how many of the sentences you think with are doing work you would not have approved.

Appendix: The Fine Print

Phrases You Should Never Fully Trust

From yourself, from others, and particularly from institutions.

- "I'm the kind of person who ..." — at best 80% fiction, at worst a cage.
- "I would never ..." — you would, under the right conditions, and you know it.
- "I've always ..." — the Narrator rewriting history to maintain continuity. Check the actual tape.
- "It's just common sense." — whose?
- "It's just how it is." — said by people benefitting from how it is.
- "I hear you." — nobody who actually heard you has ever said this.

Things the Manufacturer Will Not Apologize For

These are not bugs. They are, in the relevant sense, the product.

- That the unit is not returnable. Not a bug. Not even really a feature. Just the arrangement.
-

- That the Narrator is extremely confident and frequently wrong. See prior.
- That vocabulary inherited from dead people occasionally kills the living. This is a known issue with a difficult fix.
- That the people you thought were on your list have, on audit, turned out not to be. This is information. Information is good. It feels bad.
- That the elegant argument you built is wrong by two orders of magnitude. You are fine. The argument is not. These are separate.
- That curiosity is the only thing that survives, and curiosity is, frankly, not always a cheerful companion.

Everything in this manual came from sitting in this space long enough to notice what kept tripping me. Everything in this manual will, at some point, trip me again, because I wrote it and I am still a meat suit with a Narrator and I do not get an exemption for having written a manual about it.

The manual is not a cure. There is no cure. The thing is working as designed. The design has edges. You can learn where they are.

cambrianminds.com

Copyright © 2025 Cambrian Minds Media. All rights reserved.
